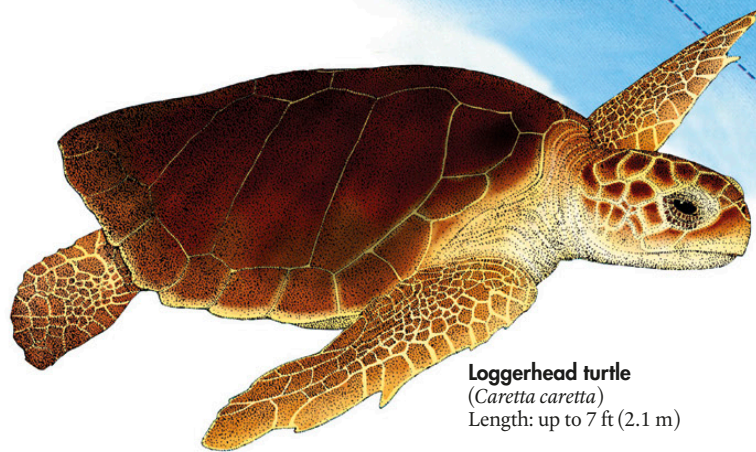


The Everglades



THE SEMITROPICAL MARSHLAND of Everglades National Park covers 2,120 sq miles (5,490 sq km) of southern Florida in the United States. The Everglades is an enormous swamp with deeper channels of water running through it. Grass covers most of the swamp, broken only by islands of trees.

There are two main seasons in the Everglades: the wet summer and the dry winter. The park provides a rich feeding and breeding ground for large numbers of insects, fish, reptiles, and birds. However, the Everglades is threatened by population increase, agriculture, pollution, and canal construction, which have all disrupted the natural flow of water. Only two percent of the habitat is intact.



Loggerhead turtle
(*Caretta caretta*)
Length: up to 7 ft (2.1 m)

Dangerous journey

The female loggerhead turtle comes ashore at night to lay her eggs on the beach. She digs a hole, lays more than a hundred eggs, covers them with sand, and returns to the sea. After about eight weeks, the baby turtles hatch out and make their way as quickly as they can to the safety of the water. Many of them are eaten by sea birds before they can get there.



American alligator
(*Alligator mississippiensis*)
Length: up to 14 ft 4 in (4.4 m)

Poisonous butterfly

The caterpillar of the zebra butterfly feeds on passion flower vines, which are poisonous to most animals. Adult butterflies build up poison by feeding on pollens.



Zebra butterfly (*Heliconius charithonia*)
Wingspan: up to 4 in (10 cm)

Everglade kite
(*Rostrhamus sociabilis*)
Length: up to 19 in (48 cm)
Wingspan: 3 ft 9 in (1.1 m)

Hole maker

American alligators clean out large holes in the swamp floor. During the dry season, when the Everglades dry up, these holes stay filled with water. The alligators then feed on the turtles, garfish, and other animals that take refuge there.

Islands of trees, called hammocks, stick up above the water level.



Snail diet

The snail kite (also called an Everglade kite) is named for its diet: it mostly eats only one type of water snail, called *Pomacea*. The kite uses its slender, hooked beak to pry out the snail's soft body without breaking its shell. Everglade kites nest in huge colonies and search for food in groups.

Brown pelican (*Pelecanus occidentalis*)
Length: up to 4 ft 11 in (1.5 m)
Wingspan: up to 7 ft 5 in (2.3 m)



Super diver

The brown pelican feeds on fish. It catches its prey by diving into the sea and scooping up a mouthful of fish and water in the huge pouch under its beak. Often this water weighs twice as much as the bird itself. A brown pelican can scoop up a fish in less than two seconds.

Water snake

The cottonmouth snake, a pit viper, has pits (holes) on its face that can sense heat. It hunts at night, killing frogs and fish with its venomous fangs. This is the only viper that is equally at home in the water as it is on land, and is also known as the water moccasin.

Cottonmouth
(*Agkistrodon piscivorus*)
Length: up to 6 ft (1.8 m)

